History of Psychology

Session 3: Psychoanalysis

Rui Mata, Center for Cognitive and Decision Sciences
October 13, 2026

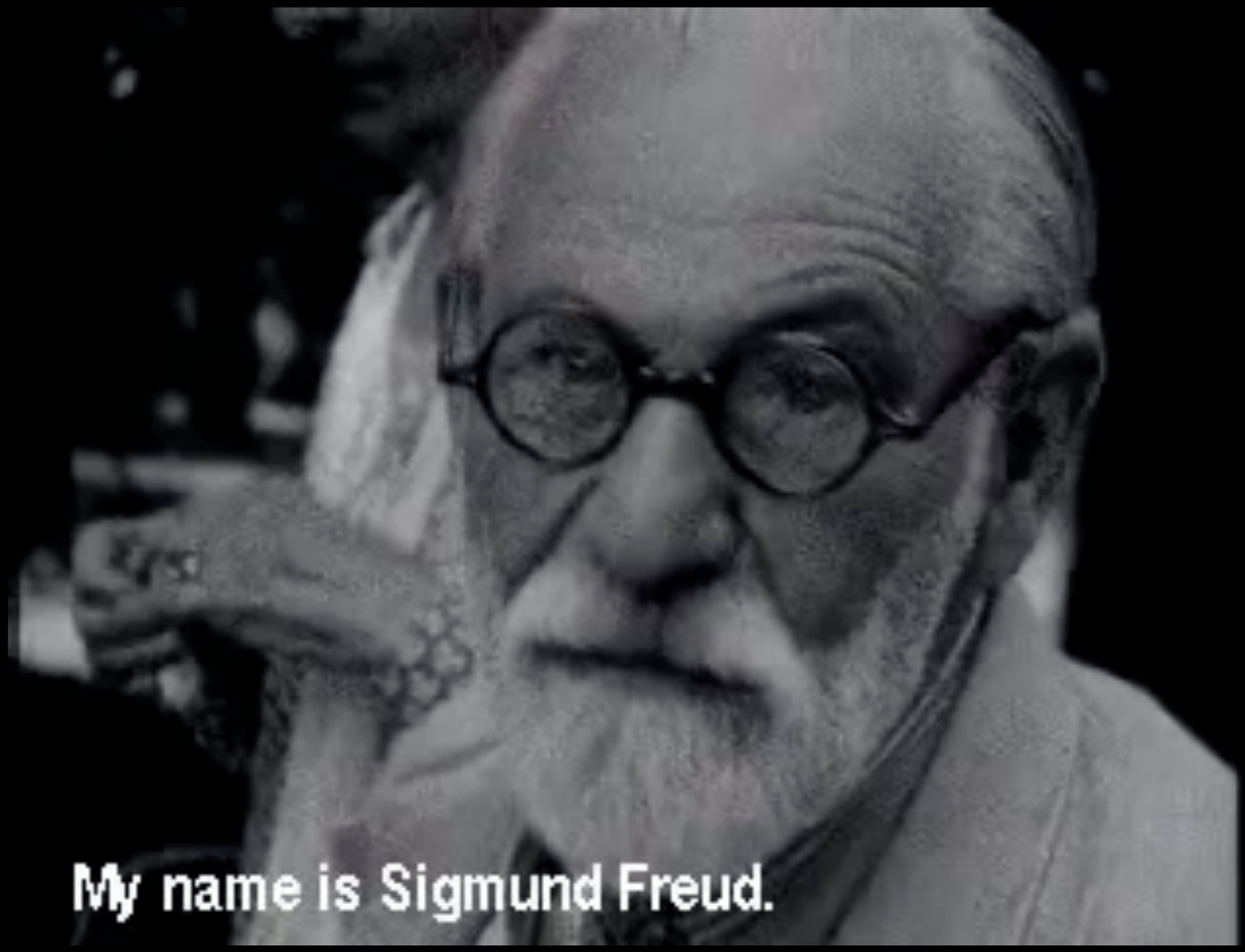
Session information

Sessions take place Tuesdays, 8.15-9.45, Kollegienhaus, Aula 033. Slides will be made available shortly before each session.

#	Date	Topic	Instructor	Resources
1	22.09.2026	What kind of science is psychology?	Mata	Spektrum Podcast
2	6.10.2026	The birth of psychology	Mata	Brysbaert & Rastle (2021; 4.1-4.2)
3	13.10.2026	Psychoanalysis	Mata	Brysbaert & Rastle (2021; 4.3-4.4)
4	20.10.2026	Behaviorism	Mata	Brysbaert & Rastle (2021; 5.2)
5	03.11.2026	Gestalt and Cognitive psychology	Mata	Brysbaert & Rastle (2021; 4.2 & 5.3)
6	10.11.2026	Psychology today	Tisdall	Spear (2007)
7	17.11.2026	Psychotherapy research	Tisdall	Braakmann (2015)
8	24.11.2026	Psychological testing	Tisdall	Wasserman (2012)
9	01.12.2026	Decision science	Tisdall	Newell et al. (2022)
10	08.12.2026	What kind of science is psychology? (revisited)	Tisdall	Ball (2012)
11	15.12.2026	Exam (see below)		

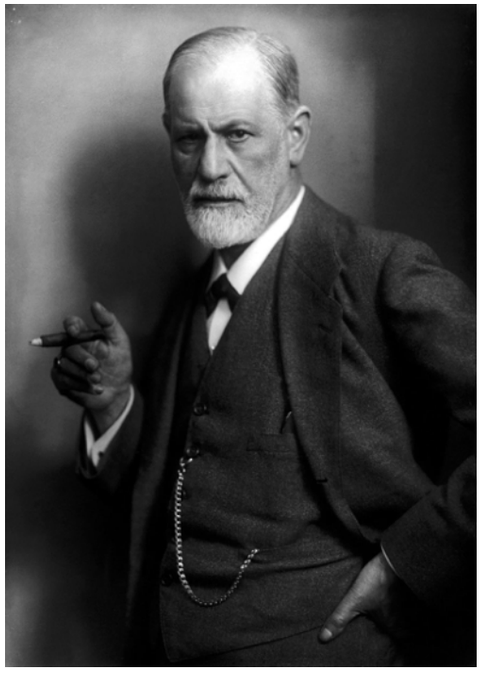
Learning Objectives for Today

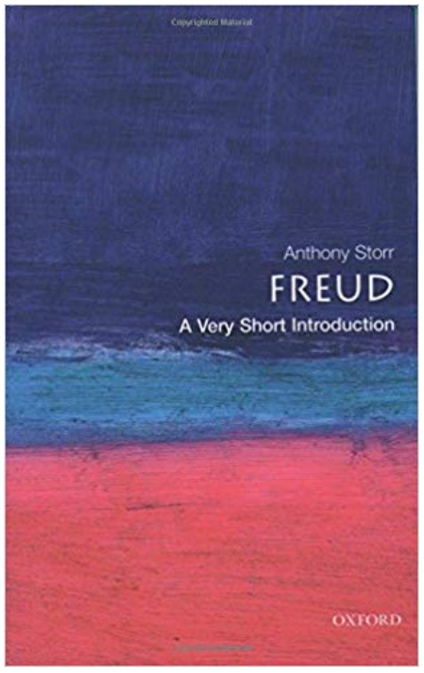
- Understand the historical context of the development of psychoanalysis, focusing on the contributions of key figures like Sigmund Freud and Carl Jung.
- Identify the key concepts and phase of Freudian psychoanalysis, including the unconscious mind, repressed trauma, and defense mechanisms.
- Explore the methods and techniques used in psychoanalysis, such as dream interpretation, free association, and projective tests.
- Discuss the impact and critiques of psychoanalysis, particularly its conflicts with behaviorism and attachment theory.



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sj2JFI4BsRQ

Sigmund Freud





Sigmund Freud (1856-1939)

- 1856 Birth in Přibor (Freiberg/Mähren; Czech Rep.)
- 1873 studies Medicine in Vienna
- 1878 name change (Sigismund Schlomo > Sigmund)
- 1881 Doctoral degree
- 1885 Habilitation in Neuropathology
- 1885-1886 Visiting researcher with Charcot in Paris
- 1886 opens private practice in Vienna
  - from 1891 at Berggasse 19 (today Freud Museum)
- 1895 publishes *Studies on Histeria* with Josef Breuer
- 1899 *The Interpretation of Dreams*
- 1902 Ordinarius at the University of Vienna
- 1909 Visit to USA, Clark University, w/ Carl Jung by invitation of G. Stanley Hall
- 1920 *Beyond the pleasure principle*
- 1938 Flees Nazis through Paris to London
  - Freuds Psychoanalysis as “jüdische Irrlehre”
- 1939 Death (assisted suicide)

The origins and development of psychoanalysis

The relationship between trauma and mental illness was first investigated by the neurologist Jean Martin Charcot, a French physician who was working with traumatized (histeric) women in the Salpêtrière hospital, Paris. Hysterical symptoms were characterized by sudden paralysis, amnesia, sensory loss, and convulsions, and at the time, such symptoms were thought to originate in the uterus.

Until Charcot, the common treatment for hysteria was hysterectomy. Charcot was the first to understand that the origin of hysterical symptoms was not physiological but rather psychological in nature. He noted that traumatic events could induce a hypnotic state in his patients and was the first to "describe both the problems of suggestibility in these patients, and the fact that hysterical attacks are dissociative problems— the results of having endured unbearable experiences"



Ringel, S. & Brandell, J.R.(2012) Trauma: Contemporary Directions in Theory, Practice, and Research. SAGE Publications: Maryland.

The origins and development of psychoanalysis

From Trauma to Phantasy

In Studies on Hysteria (1895), coauthored with Josef Breuer, Freud suggested that

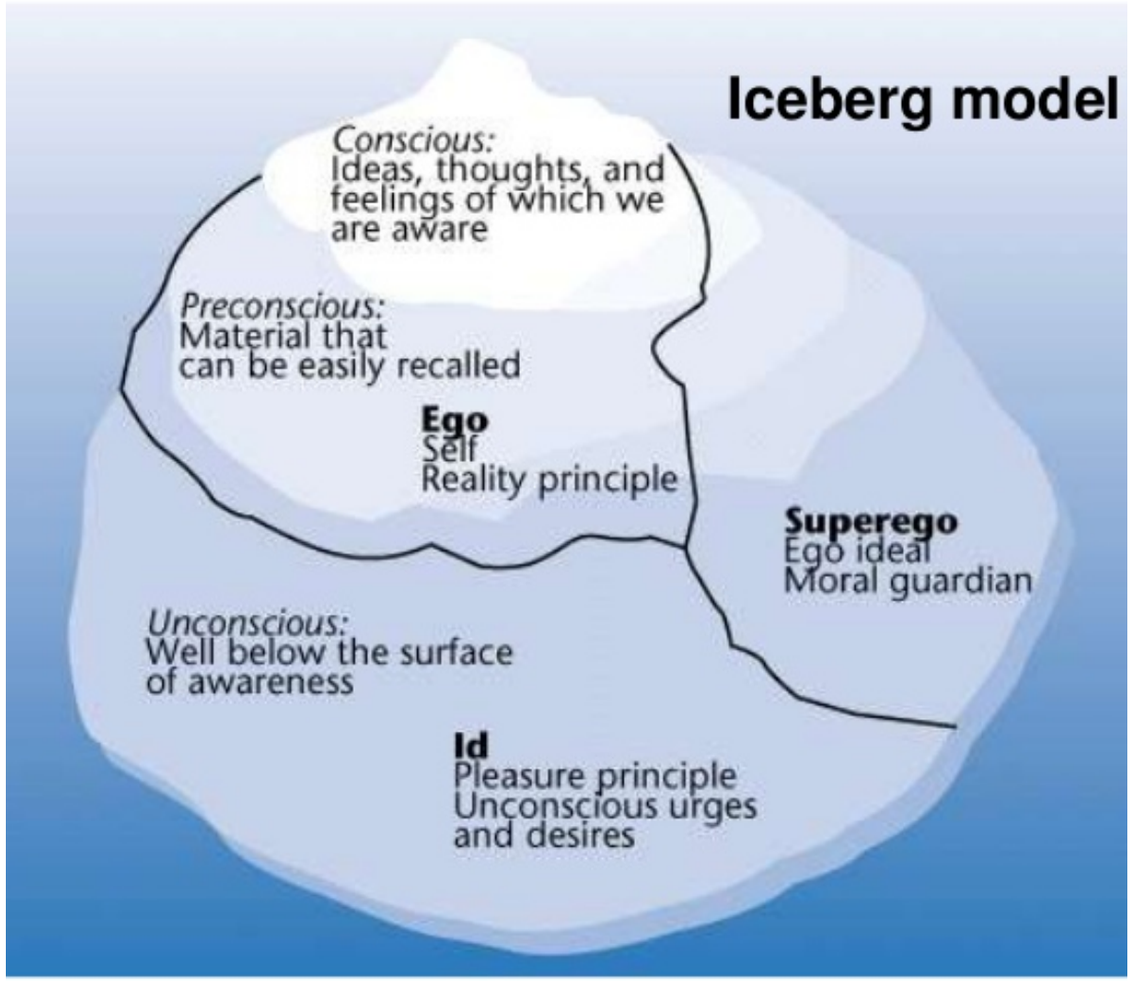
"we must point out that we consider it essential for the explanation of hysterical phenomena to assume the presence of a dissociation, a splitting of the content of consciousness. [T]he regular and essential content of a hysterical attack is the recurrence of a physical state which the patient has experienced earlier."

Later, Freud stopped believing that every client who walked into his office with 'hysteria' had been sexually abused. Rather, he seemed to believe that symptoms resulted from repressed phantasies.

Ringel, S. & Brandell, J.R.(2012) Trauma: Contemporary Directions in Theory, Practice, and Research. SAGE Publications: Maryland.

Psychoanalysis: Theses (and phases)

- Psychoanalysis as …
  - General theory of human psychology and behavior
  - Method to diagnose and treat psychopathology
  - Historical-cultural movement
- Phases of Psychoanalytic Theory
  - Pre-psychoanalysis (1881-1894)
  - Trauma theory (1895-1899)
    - repressed traumas
    - reinterpretation as phantasies (castration complex, penis envy, Oedipus complex)
  - Topographical Theory (1900-1922)
    - Levels of conscious access
  - Structural Theory (1923 onwards)
    - Id, Ego, Super Ego
    - Es = Eros (Desire) und Thanatos (Death)



Theses: According to Psychoanalysis, human behaviour is largely influenced by drives that are rooted in the unconscious; mental/emotional disturbances (e.g., depression, anxiety) arise from conflicts between the conscious and the unconscious.

Psychoanalysis: Examples of Defense Mechanisms

Defense Mechanism	Description	Example
Repression	Unknowingly placing an unpleasant memory or thought in the unconscious	Not remembering a traumatic incident in which you witnessed a crime
Regression	Reverting back to immature behavior from an earlier stage of development	Throwing temper tantrums as an adult when you don't get your way
Displacement	Redirecting unacceptable feelings from the original source to a safer, substitute target	Taking your anger toward your boss out on your spouse or children by yelling at them and not your boss
Sublimation	Replacing socially unacceptable impulses with socially acceptable behavior	Channeling aggressive drives into playing football or inappropriate sexual desires into art
Reaction formation	Acting in exactly the opposite way to one's unacceptable impulses	Being overprotective of and lavishing attention on an unwanted child
Projection	Attributing one's own unacceptable feelings and thoughts to others and not yourself	Accusing your boyfriend of cheating on you because you have felt like cheating on him
Rationalization	Creating false excuses for one's unacceptable feelings, thoughts, or behavior	Justifying cheating on an exam by saying that everyone else cheats

Psychoanalysis: Methods



- Freud based his theories on observation of clinical cases; initially he used hypnosis, but from 1892 onwards, he started relying more on free association and, later (ca. 1895) dream interpretation.

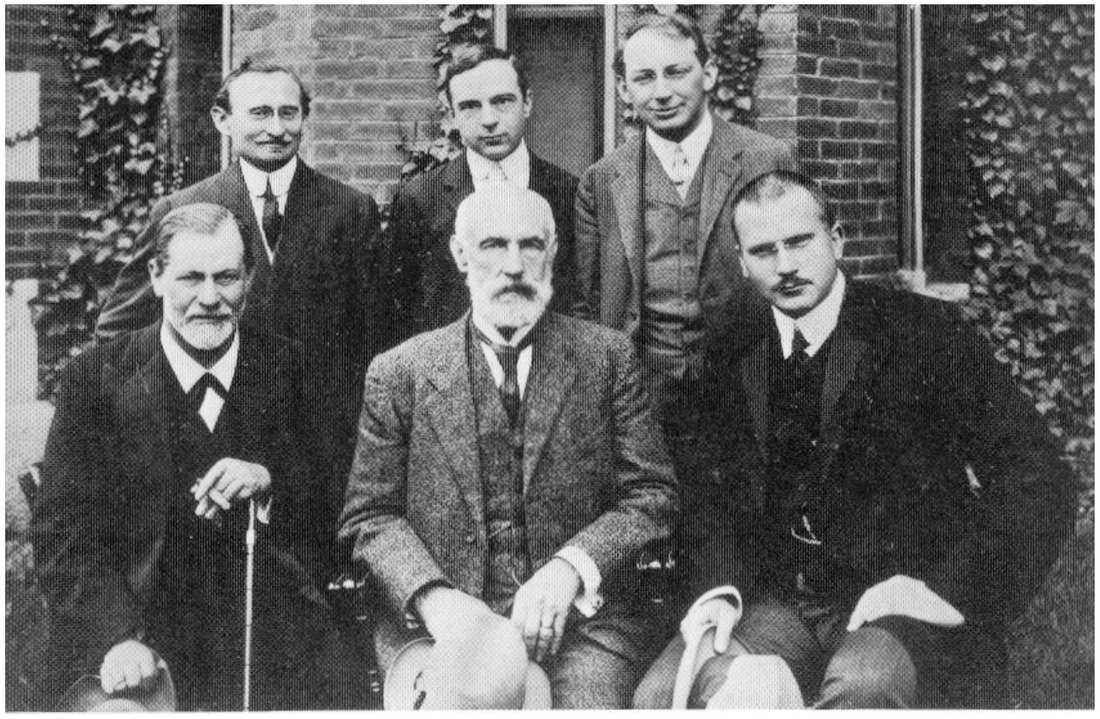
Psychoanalysis: Methods

- **Anamnesis**: interpretation of patient biography in light of psychoanalysis, to reveal origins of trauma/conflict and defence mechanisms at play; bringing these to light and new framing may help resolve tensions
- **Hypnosis**: probe the unconscious and cure (hypnotic suggestion), abandoned
- **Dream analysis**: dreams as “the royal road” to the unconscious (like hypnosis, represents an altered state of consciousness), dreams deal with wish fulfilment, unconscious desires and conflicts; dreams contain both manifest (conscious) and latent content, with the latter representing repressed, symbolic meaning. The therapist aims to uncover the meaning of the latent content and uses additional techniques (e.g., free association) to further probe the mental conflict
- **Free association**: the analyst asks the individual to share thoughts, words, or images that come freely to mind or in reaction to some cue; the results are interpreted by the analyst to uncover unconscious thoughts and conflict
- **Freudian slips** (i.e., slips of the tongue; “bread and butter” -> “bed and butter”): investigative technique to reveal sources of mental conflict
- **Projective tests**: psychoanalysts aim to uncover unconscious drives and conflicts by interpreting responses to ambiguous cues (e.g., Rorschach ink blots)



In 1909 Jung and Freud sailed to the United States at the invitation of Clark University.

Psychoanalysis: Impact (and Conflict)



Clark University, Mass., USA, September 1909. Front row: Sigmund Freud, G. Stanley Hall, Carl Jung. Stanley Hall studied with Wundt in Leipzig, was a pioneer in Developmental Psychology and founder of the American Psychological Association (APA). Freud and Jung, among others. were invited to the 10-year Anniversary of Clark University and awarded Honorary Doctorates. Soon after, however, Freud and Jung would go their separate ways once Jung published *Wandlungen und Symbole der Libido* (1912) detailing his analytical psychology.

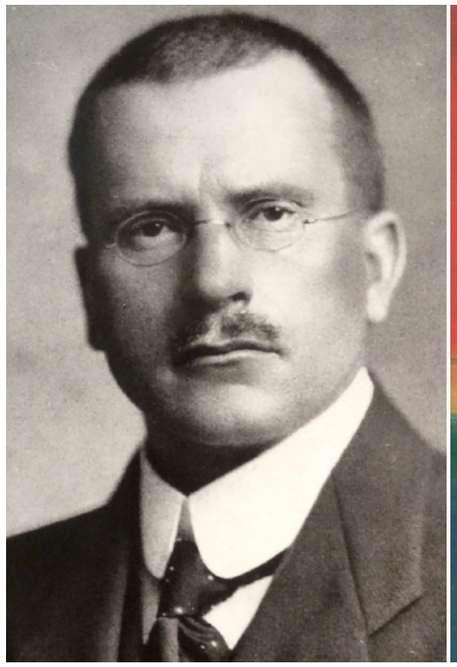
Freud on receiving his honorary doctorate

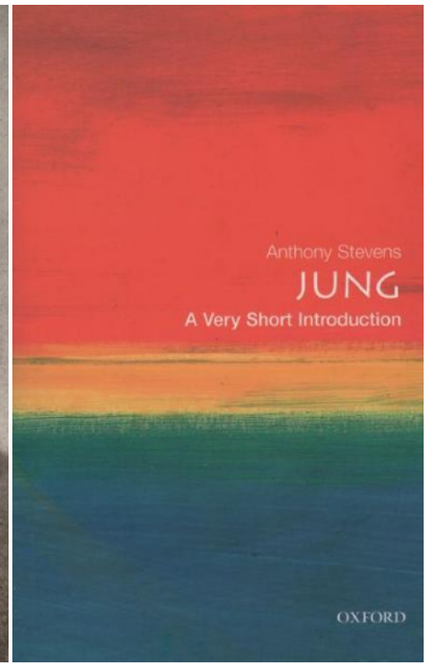
"In Europe I felt as though I were despised; but over there I found myself received by the foremost men as an equal. As I stepped onto the platform at Worcester to deliver my Five Lectures upon Psychoanalysis it seemed like the realization of some incredible day-dream: psychoanalysis was no longer a product of delusion, it had become a valuable part of reality."

The Great Schism…

»Ich erinnere mich noch lebhaft, wie Freud zu mir sagte: Mein lieber Jung, versprechen Sie mir, nie die Sexualtheorie aufzugeben. Das ist das Allerwesentlichste. Sehen Sie, wir müssen daraus ein Dogma machen, ein unerschütterliches Bollwerk. Das sagte er mir voll Leidenschaft und in einem Ton, als sagte ein Vater: Und versprich mir eines, mein lieber Sohn: geh jeden Sonntag in die Kirche! (…) Freud, der stets mit Nachdruck auf seine Irreligiosität hinwies, hatte sich ein Dogma zurechtgelegt, oder vielmehr, anstelle eines ihm verlorengegangenen, eifersüchtigen Gottes hatte sich ein anderes zwingendes Bild, nämlich der Sexualität, unterschoben; ein Bild, das nicht weniger drängend, anspruchsvoll, gebieterisch, bedrohlich und moralisch ambivalent war. (…) Gegen diese Einseitigkeit Freuds war nichts zu machen. (…) Er blieb dem einen Aspekt verfallen, und eben darum sehe ich in ihm eine tragische Gestalt…« (Jung, 1963, S. 155 ff.).

Carl Gustav Jung





Carl Gustav Jung (1875-1961)

- 1875 Born in Kesswil (Bodensee)
- 1895 Studies Medicine in Basel
- 1900 Psychiatric Hospital Burghölzli (Zürich): Assistant to Eugen Bleuler (1857-1939); experiments with word associations and reaction times to understand pathology
- 1902 Doctorate
- 1907 Contact with Freud
- 1909 Travels with Freud to Clark University
- 1909 Leaves Burghölzli (disagreement with Bleuler)
- 1910-1914 President „Internat. Psychoanalytic Association“
- 1912 „Wandlungen und Symbole der Libido“
- 1913 Rupture with Freud
- 1913 House and work at Küsnacht (Zürichsee)
- 1933-1942 Professorship in Zürich
- 1944 Professorship in Basel (for only 1 year)
- 1946 Retirement
- 1961 Death

“Die tatsächlich bestehenden und einsichtigen Leuten schon längst bekannten Verschiedenheiten der germanischen und der jüdischen Psychologie sollen nicht mehr verwischt werden, was der Wissenschaft nur förderlich sein kann.”

C. G. Jung, *Geleitwort* im *Zentralblatt für Psychotherapie und ihre Grenzgebiete* VI/3 (Leipzig 1933).

Carl Gustav Jung

- Libido as a more general term to describe mental energy (as opposed to sexual energy)
- Collective unconscious: aspects of unconsciousness experienced by all people in different times and cultures
- Archetypes
  - inherited images, symbols (e.g., giants, magicians, heroes)
  - double-nature as instincts and cultural traditions
  - as foundation of human communion
- Personality types
  - distinguish introverts (focused on the internal world) and extroverts (focused on the external world)
- Publication record
  - little systematic treatment of theoretical ideas
  - publications on religion, mystical topics, alchemy…

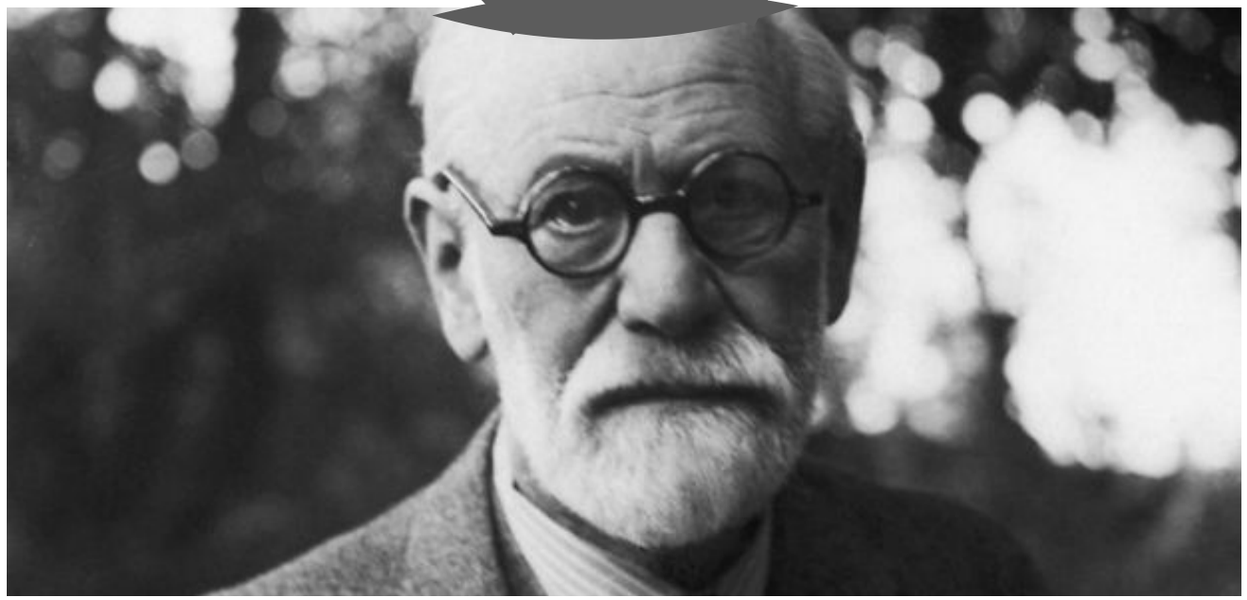
Analytical Psychology
less focus on sexuality, focus on personality types and archetypes

Individual Psychology
neuroses arise from overcompensation for feelings of insecurity

Active Therapy
therapist plays more active role

“Modern” Freudian Psychoanalysis
continuation of ideas but new foci (child psychoanalysis), new techniques (children drawings) or emphasis on specific mechanisms (transference)





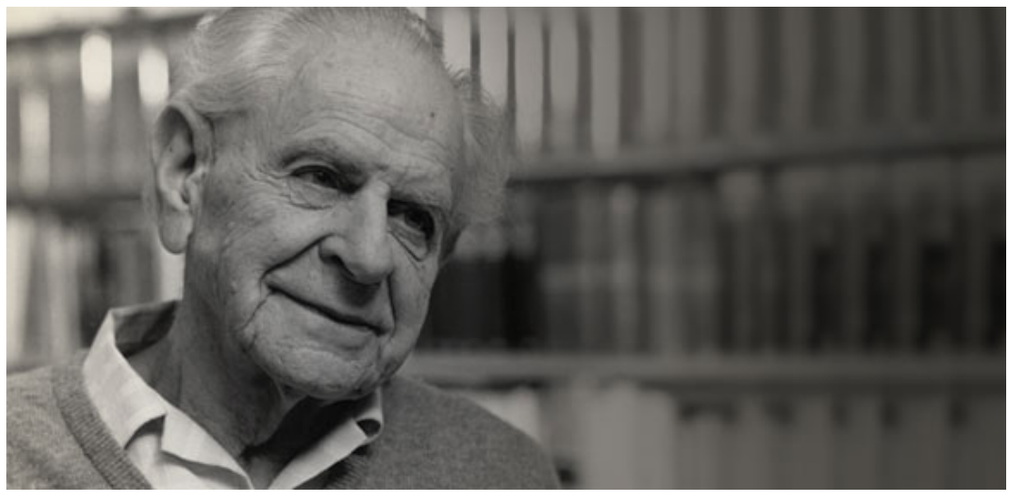
Psychoanalysis: Critique

- Freud seems to have paid little interest to systematic empirical research:

  “Ich habe ihre experimentellen Arbeiten zur Prüfung psychoanalytischer Behauptungen mit Interesse zur Kenntnis genommen. Sehr hoch kann ich diese Bestätigungen nicht einschätzen, denn die Fülle sicherer Beobachtungen, auf denen jene Beobachtungen beruhen, macht sie von der experimentellen Prüfung unabhängig. Immerhin, sie kann nicht schaden.”

  Freud (letter to Saul Rosenzweig, 1934)

Psychoanalysis: Critique



Karl Popper
1902-1994

Karl Popper critiqued psychoanalysis for being unfalsifiable, meaning it could not be empirically tested or disproven, a key criterion for scientific theories in his view. Popper argued that psychoanalytic theories, such as Freud's ideas about the unconscious mind and repressed desires, could explain any possible behavior, making them flexible and adaptable to all outcomes. This adaptability, according to Popper, rendered the theory scientifically weak because no observation could potentially prove it wrong. As a result, Popper classified psychoanalysis as a pseudoscience, contrasting it with scientific theories that make bold predictions, which can be tested and potentially refuted.

Psychoanalysis: Critique

"Everybody has won, and all must have prizes."

Carroll, Lewis (1865). Alice's Adventures in Wonderland.



Dodo bird verdict

A controversial topic in psychotherapy, referring to the claim that all psychotherapies, regardless of their specific components, produce equivalent outcomes. The conjecture was introduced by Saul Rosenzweig in 1936, drawing on imagery from Lewis Carroll's novel Alice's Adventures in Wonderland. More info in the session Psychotherapy Research.

Psychoanalysis: Impact (and Conflict)

Historians' and Chairpersons' Rankings of the Importance of All-Time and Contemporary Psychologists

Historians[a]			Chairpersons[b]		
Rank	Individual	Rank points	Rank	Individual	Rank points
		All-time rankings			
1	Wundt, W.	189	1	Skinner, B. F.	508
2	James, W.	167	2	Freud, S.	459
3	Freud, S.	156	3	James, W.	372
4	Watson, J.	108	4	Piaget, J.	237
5	Pavlov, I.	79	5	Hall, G. S.	216
6	Ebbinghaus, H.	69	6	Wundt, W.	203
7	Piaget, J.	51	7	Rogers, C.	192
8	Skinner, B. F.	46	8	Watson, J.	188
9	Binet, A.	46	9	Pavlov, I.	152
10	Fechner, G.	46	10	Thorndike, E. L.	124

Korn, J. H., Davis, R., & Davis, S. F. (1991). Historians' and chairpersons' judgments of eminence among psychologists. *American Psychologist, 46*(7), 789–792. doi: 10.1037/0003-066X.46.7.789

Psychoanalysis vs. Behaviorism



– Watson's investigation of children's conditioning can be seen partly as a response to psychoanalysis' focus on early childhood - see session "Behaviorism"

Watson, J. B., & Rayner, R. (1920). Conditioned emotional reactions. *Journal of Experimental Psychology, 3*(1), 1-14.

Psychoanalysis vs. Attachment Theory

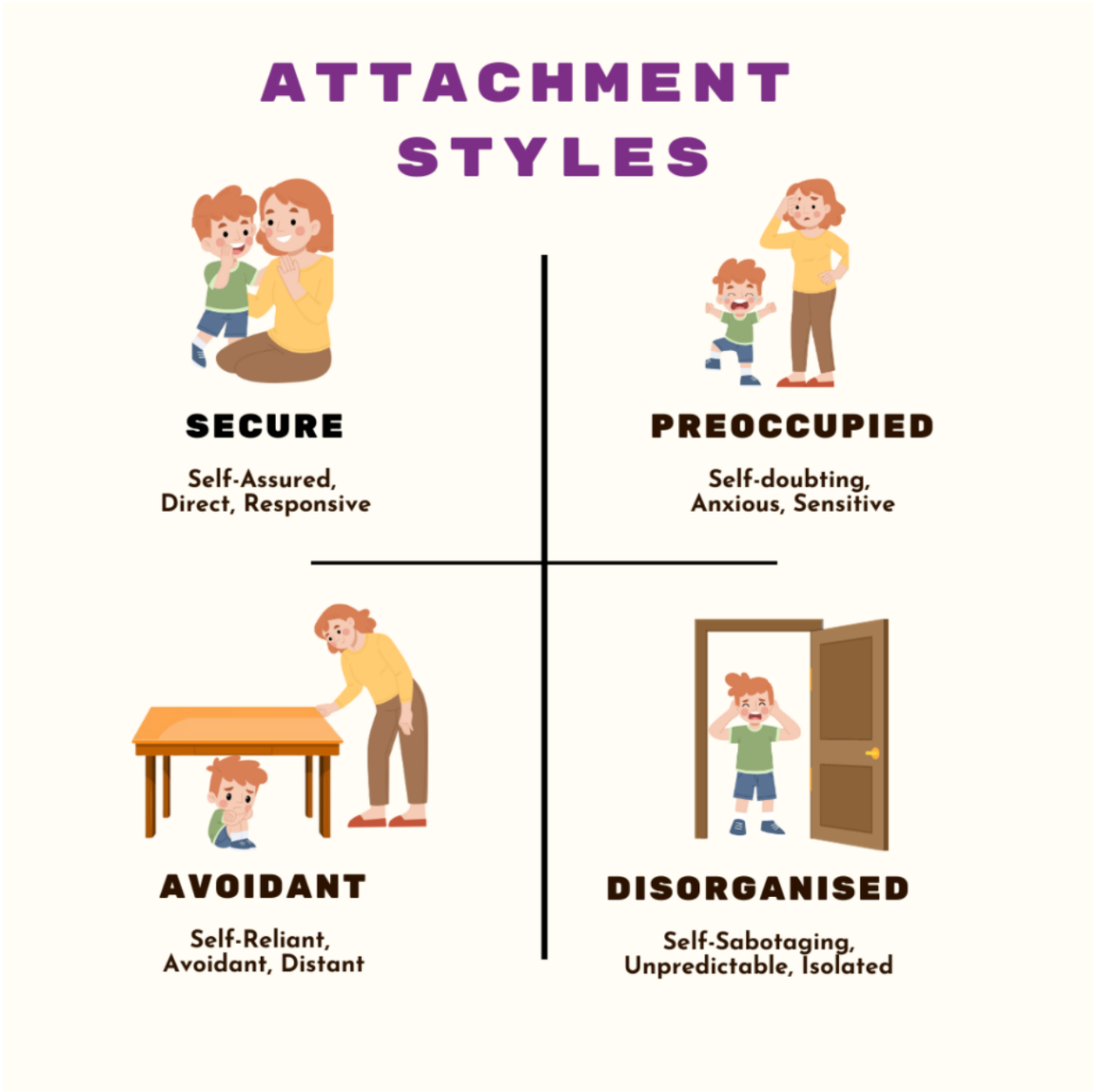


Mary Ainswoth
(1913-1999)

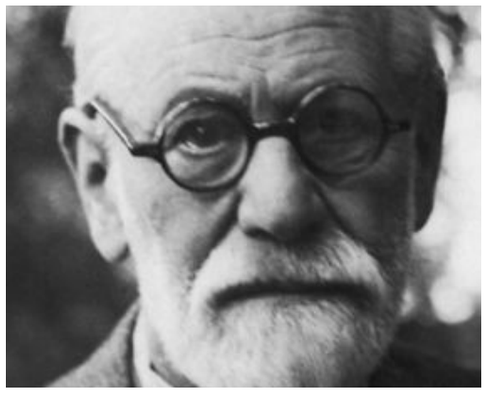
- 1913 Born in Ohio
- 1939 PhD Developmental Psychology (Univ Toronto) worked with William Blatz who rejected Freudian theories asserting that "it is not necessary to postulate an unconscious"; applied security theory to understand how children strive for security (at first dependent of caregivers and, later, dependent on own skills)
- 1942 Joined Canadian Army Corps (testing and personnel selection)
- 1950 Moved to London, worked with John Bowlby (psychiatrist interested in patterns of family interaction), where she studied maternal-infant attachments (comparison of disrupted mother-child vs normal mother-child bonds)
- 1954 East African Institute of Social Research, Kampala, Uganda: mother-infant observations
- 1956 Johns Hopkins University (first on a temporary position)
- 1965: Strange Situation Procedure: assessment child attachment by observing children's behaviour when separated and reunited with their mother
- 1975 University of Virginia
- 1992 Retirement
- 1999 Death

Psychoanalysis vs. Attachment Theory

The Ainsworth Strange Situation Paradigm is a structured observational method used to assess attachment between a caregiver and a child. The procedure involves a series of separations and reunions between the caregiver and child, along with the introduction of a stranger, to observe the child's responses. Based on these interactions, Ainsworth identified different attachment styles (e.g., secure, avoidant). The method helps understand the nature of the child's attachment and emotional bond with the caregiver.



Psychoanalysis vs. Attachment Theory





Psychoanalysis

- Drives as primary
- Objects (attachment figures) secondary to drive gratification
- Normative view: Sexuality and aggression as primary drives

Attachment Theory

- Primacy of caregiving function (imprinting)
- Learning and independence as a motivating force in development
- Individual differences

Ainsworth, M. D. (1969). Object relations, dependency, and attachment: A theoretical review of the infant-mother relationship. *Child Development, 40*(4), 969–1025.

Summary: Psychoanalysis

- **The power of the unconscious**: Central to psychoanalysis is the exploration of the unconscious, where repressed desires and conflicts reside. Psychoanalysis seeks to uncover these unconscious drives and understand how they conflict with conscious thoughts, influencing behavior and mental health.

- **Pathology, sexuality, and beyond**: Freud emphasized that many psychological issues stem from trauma and sexuality, and other psychological problems arising from parent-child relations; theory of drives and psychological defence mechanisms; initial focus on sexuality, later on death and aggression; progression of theory and techniques; plural methodology (e.g., interpretation of dreams, free association, projective tests).

- **Therapeutic focus**: psychoanalysis was proposed as a therapeutic method, techniques like dream interpretation, free association, and projective tests were introduced to bring unconscious conflicts to light, aiding in the resolution of psychological conflict.

- **Impact and critique**: Psychoanalysis as opposition to the medical/biological model and opposition to mainstream psychology's focus on consciousness; emphasis on clinical experience relative to quantification/experimentation; influence on different views through opposition by close (e.g., Jung, Adler) and more distant perspectives (e.g., behaviorism, attachment theory).

WHAT DO YOU THINK?

Compare and contrast the schools: structuralism, functionalism, psychoanalysis

